READBACK

AI ATC FOR DCS

Installation Guide

Readback ATC gives your DCS World server AI air traffic controllers that talk to your pilots over DCS-SRS: towers with ATIS, Command, AWACS, carrier Marshal, Deckboss and Paddles, tankers and JTAC.

1. What you need

Item	Notes
The PC that runs your DCS-SRS server	Windows 10 or 11, 64-bit. Readback must run on the same PC as the SRS server: SRS only accepts Readback's radio transmissions from that PC.
DCS-SRS 2.4 or newer	With **External AWACS Mode** (EAM) switched on in the SRS server and a password set. Readback joins SRS through it.
Microsoft .NET 10 Desktop Runtime (x64)	DCS-SRS 2.4 and its installer need it. Install it before DCS-SRS: dotnet.microsoft.com/download/dotnet/10.0
An OpenAI API key	Required: it is how Readback understands what your pilots say. Billed by OpenAI per use. Create one at platform.openai.com/api-keys.
An ElevenLabs API key	Optional: more natural voices for the controllers that have one.
Tacview real-time telemetry	Optional but recommended: Command, AWACS, traffic calls and position checks use it to see the aircraft. Turn on real-time telemetry in Tacview on the DCS server.
ffmpeg	Required: Readback uses it to hear your pilots' radio calls (and for the radio sound). Readback-Setup offers to install it for you. To do it yourself, open Command Prompt and run `winget install --id Gyan.FFmpeg -e`, or unzip *ffmpeg-master-latest-win64-gpl* from github.com/BtbN/FFmpeg-Builds/releases to `C:\ffmpeg-master-latest-win64-gpl`.

2. Install

1. **Run Readback-Setup.exe** on the SRS server PC. No administrator rights are needed.
2. If Windows shows **"Windows protected your PC"**, click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.

3. Readback installs to `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Readback ATC` and adds **Readback ATC** to the Start menu and the desktop. It asks whether to start Readback when Windows starts.
4. It checks this PC for .NET 10, DCS-SRS and ffmpeg. It offers to install ffmpeg (through Windows' winget) and to open the download page for anything else missing.
5. It starts Readback and opens **Setup** in your browser.

> The dashboard is always at **http://localhost:7000** on this PC. Other PCs on your network can open it at **http://<this PC's address>:7000**. If Windows asks whether to let Readback through the firewall, allow private networks.

3. Setup

Setup walks you through six steps. You can go back to any step, and change everything later in **Settings**.

1. **Squadron**: your squadron's name and logo (.png or .jpg). They appear on every page.
2. **Voice**: paste your OpenAI key, and your ElevenLabs key if you have one. Each key is tested before it is saved. Keys stay on this PC.
3. **Server**: the SRS server (usually `localhost:5002`), its External AWACS Mode password, and Tacview's real-time telemetry address (usually `localhost:42674`). Each is tested when you save it.
4. **Theatre**: pick the map your server flies and click **Create start files**. Choose whether you want the AWACS controller (callsign and frequency) and carrier operations (Marshal and Deckboss). Untick any station or field you don't want.
5. **Test call**: tune an SRS radio to the frequency shown, click **Send test call**, and listen for *"Radio check. This is Readback..."*. If you hear it, everything works.
6. **Ready**: check the list, then **Start** the theatre.

4. Voices

Readback starts with the free **Windows voices**. For natural voices with regional accents, turn on **OpenAI voices** in Settings > Voice services (a fraction of a cent per transmission). With an ElevenLabs key, the controllers that have an ElevenLabs voice use it.

5. Trial and licence

Readback runs as a **14-day trial** from the first start. The dashboard shows the days left. To keep it running, buy a licence key and paste it into **Settings > Licence**. Keys start with `READBACK1-`.

A key with an end date is shown on the dashboard, which warns you two weeks before it ends. After the end date Readback keeps running for a **7-day grace period**, so a late renewal never stops a flying night; then the controllers stop starting until the renewed key is entered. Nothing is lost: enter the new key and carry on. A controller already running is never stopped part-way through a session.

6. Updates

Readback checks for new versions once a day. When one is out, the dashboard shows **Update available**: open **Settings > Updates**, read what's new and click **Update now**. Readback downloads it, checks it, installs it and restarts, and the controllers that were running start again. Your settings stay.

7. Uninstall

Start menu > **Uninstall Readback ATC**. It removes the programs and shortcuts and leaves your settings, start files and logs in `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Readback ATC`; delete that folder to remove them too.

8. Troubleshooting

You see	Do this
Test call: *"SRS ExternalAudio needs Microsoft .NET 10"*	Install the .NET 10 Desktop Runtime (x64), then send the test call again.
Test call: *"SRS ExternalAudio not found"*	Install DCS-SRS on this PC with its installer.
Test call: *"SRS did not take the transmission"*	Check the SRS server is running on this PC, the port in Settings matches it, and External AWACS Mode is on.
The test call is sent but you hear nothing	Check your SRS radio is on the same frequency and in AM for UHF/VHF, and that your SRS client is connected to this server.
Pilots get no answer	Make sure the controller is running on the dashboard, the pilot calls the right station first (*"Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, radio check"*), and the OpenAI key works (Settings > Test).
"The 14-day trial has ended"	Enter a licence key in Settings > Licence.
The dashboard does not open	Another program may be using port 7000. Close it, then start Readback ATC from the Start menu.

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